Apgar Score — Newborn

all newborns · labour ward / casualty · record at 1 and 5 min

Apgar 0–10

APGAR SCORE ✚

Sign	0	1	2
Heart rate	Absent	<100/min	>100/min
Respiration	Absent	Slow or irregular	Good, crying
Muscle tone	Limp	Slight flexion	Active, moves
Response to stimulation	No response	Grimace	Vigorous cry
Colour	Blue or pale	Body pink, limbs blue	Pink all over

FORMULA

Apgar ✚: **Sum of 5 signs (0–2 each) = 0–10**
Timing: **1 min and 5 min; if <7 at 5 min, repeat every 5 min to 20 min** · AAP/ACOG

PEARLS

- Never wait for the 1-min Apgar to start resuscitation — breathing and heart rate guide it
- Apgar alone does not diagnose asphyxia; record cord pH/BD when available
- Mnemonic: Appearance, Pulse, Grimace, Activity, Respiration

INTERPRETATION

- **7–10** Reassuring
- **4–6** Moderately abnormal
- **0–3** Low

SA GUIDELINES

- Check and record the Apgar score after birth ✚
- Refer to a neonatal unit if Apgar <8 at 5 minutes ✚
- 5-min Apgar <7: follow the post-birth action flowchart ✚
- HIE cooling criterion: Apgar <5 at 5 AND 10 min (or pH <7.0 & BD ≥12, or resus >10 min) ✚

PHC STG & EML Primary Healthcare, 8th ed. 2024 (updated Sept 2026) — pp 6.26, 6.27 · **MAT24** National Integrated Maternal & Perinatal Care Guidelines for SA, 5th ed. 2024 — pp 74 · **PAED** STG & EML Paediatric Hospital Level, 2025-2029 cycle (updated Mar 2026) — pp 19.43
✚ = SA STG / national guideline (pages listed above). Unmarked content: international source named above. ‡ = STG misprint or sources differ (see app). ANDH · apgar · updated 2026-10-14